

Survey report by Finextra Research,
in association with ACI Worldwide
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ACI Worldwide®

AI IN ACTION: GLOBAL SURVEY ON FRAUD AND FINANCIAL CRIME

REAL-WORLD INSIGHTS ON HOW AI IS TRANSFORMING
FRAUD STRATEGIES WORLDWIDE.



Finextra®

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Foreword



Adriana Iordan,
Head of Merchant and
Payments Intelligence,
Product Management

ACI Worldwide

The global payments ecosystem is undergoing rapid transformation, driven by advancements in technology, digital adoption, and shifting regulatory landscapes. Fraud and financial crime are no longer isolated challenges; they have evolved into systemic risks that threaten the integrity of the entire financial system. Organisations must rethink their approach to security, adopting strategies that integrate intelligence, agility, and collaboration at scale.

As this report illustrates, artificial intelligence (AI) is fundamentally reshaping how businesses address fraud prevention. AI is

becoming the cornerstone of trust in digital commerce, helping to redefine not only how fraud is detected and prevented but also how financial institutions engage with their customers. Through the power of machine learning, predictive analytics, and real-time decision-making, AI is elevating fraud detection from a reactive process to a proactive and intelligent action.

However, while AI holds immense potential, the journey toward its full integration is complex. The data presented in this report reveals that while 51% of organisations have already deployed AI, and 47% are in the process of doing so, only 19% operate with full autonomy — most still rely heavily on human oversight, an approach that constrains scale and slows response times as fraud accelerates. Chief among the challenges are issues surrounding trust in AI's ability to deliver consistent and reliable results, the ongoing shortage of talent in the AI field, and the ever-evolving compliance requirements that govern how data can be used. These challenges underscore a crucial point: the implementation of AI in fraud and financial crime prevention is not merely a technology-driven decision; it is a strategic, organisational imperative.

Perhaps most striking, data privacy risks in AI training have emerged as the top concern — overtaking fraud itself — reinforcing that how we handle data is now as critical as how we detect threats.

For businesses to remain competitive and sustainable in this rapidly changing landscape, they must embrace a shift in perspective. As funds move instantly, institutions are forced to assess identity, intent, and reimbursement eligibility in real time. Fraud and liability are becoming instantaneous decisions, straining traditional refund and dispute frameworks.

The ability to balance immediate concerns, such as mitigating fraud risks, with broader strategic goals, such as customer trust and regulatory compliance, is essential for future-proofing organisations.

At ACI Worldwide, we view these challenges as opportunities. Real-time AI decisioning, ethical data practices, and secure intelligence sharing are no longer optional — they are the foundation of a resilient payments ecosystem.

This report is a call to action. The future belongs to those who blend innovation with responsibility, using disruption as a force to build trust rather than undermine it.



Keith Briscoe,
Vice President
Advocacy and
Education

Merchant Risk Council

Fraud and financial crime are evolving faster than ever, powered by the same technologies that organisations are adopting to protect themselves. The findings in this report capture how industry leaders are experiencing this disruption, highlighting both the scale of the challenge and the opportunities to respond with innovation and collaboration.

Artificial intelligence is no longer a distant disruptor; it is embedded in the daily operations of both legitimate businesses and bad actors. Fraudsters are using AI to scale attacks, automate deception, and adapt in real

time. To stay ahead, financial institutions and merchants alike must deploy systems that learn, adapt, and respond with equal speed and precision.

The influence of AI extends beyond today's threats. It is reshaping commerce itself, introducing new risks and new questions for fraud prevention. As agent driven transactions become more common, verifying identity will no longer be enough. The challenge will be to validate intent. Was a transaction truly authorised by the customer, or by a compromised agent acting in their name? Addressing this frontier will require new trust frameworks and closer alignment between fraud, cybersecurity, and identity management teams.

Meeting these challenges demands more than technology. The industry has long recognised the value of intelligence sharing, yet silos persist. Competitive pressures, regulatory uncertainty, and cultural barriers continue to slow the flow of actionable insights across merchants, financial institutions, and networks. The future of fraud prevention lies in secure, privacy preserving data collaboration — sharing patterns, signals, and anomalies that reveal emerging threats without compromising customer privacy.

Instant payments add urgency to this mission. They deliver speed and convenience that customers expect, but they also leave little room for traditional review processes. Liability frameworks must evolve so that every participant in the payments chain has both the incentive and the capability to prevent fraud before funds move. This is not just a technology issue; it is a governance challenge that calls for industry-wide alignment. Organisations must also look inward. Fraud prevention cannot operate in isolation from cybersecurity, compliance, or customer experience. The same signals that detect fraud can inform marketing, product design, and risk strategy. By integrating these functions, institutions can close blind spots and turn fraud prevention into a driver of trust and growth.

Collaboration remains the most powerful force multiplier. Industry forums, cross sector partnerships, and regulatory engagement are essential to surfacing emerging threats, sharing best practices, and amplifying collective intelligence. The pace of change demands continuous, real-time engagement rather than periodic updates.

The challenges ahead are significant, but so are the opportunities. AI, when applied responsibly and collectively, can tip the balance in favour of the defenders. By sharing intelligence, aligning incentives, and integrating efforts across the ecosystem, the industry can not only keep pace with fraudsters but out innovate them. This report provides a timely lens on those dynamics, surfacing the perspectives of leaders who are shaping the future of fraud prevention and reinforcing the importance of working together to protect the integrity of the global payments system.

Methodology

Finextra Research, commissioned by ACI Worldwide, conducted a global survey of 154 respondents in summer 2025 across Europe (including the UK), North America (NA), Middle East, Africa, and South Asia (MEASA), and Asia Pacific (APAC).

Survey participants held roles with titles ranging from C-level, executive vice president, senior vice president, vice president, senior director, director, and senior manager across revenue based organisations (including merchants and payment processors), and asset based organisations (including merchant acquiring, card issuing, and financial technology or infrastructure providers).

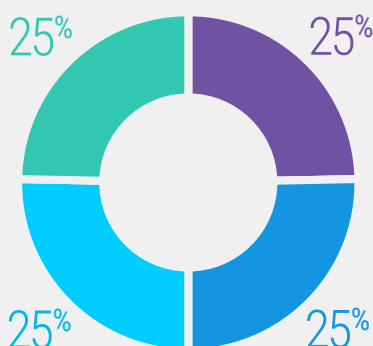
The sample included participants from organisations with revenues ranging from under \$250 million to over \$1 billion, or assets ranging from under \$10 billion to over \$250 billion.

The full sample breakdowns by region, organisation type, and role level are shown below.

All survey responses were conducted on a confidential basis.

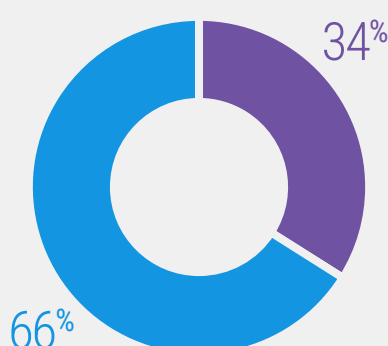
DEMOGRAPHIC SPLITS

Region



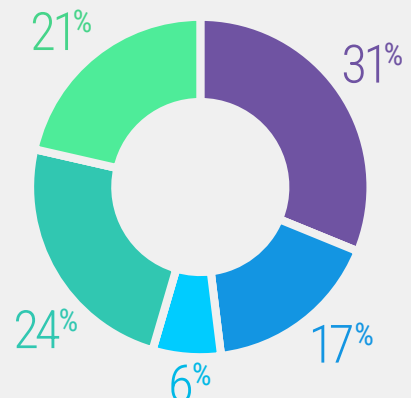
- Europe (including the UK)
- North America
- Middle East, Africa, and South Asia
- Asia Pacific

Organisation type



- Revenue based (merchants and payment processors)
- Asset based (merchant acquiring, card issuing, and financial technology or infrastructure providers)

Role level



- C-level
- Executive vice president, senior vice president or senior director
- Vice president
- Director
- Senior manager

03

Executive insights

01 AI moves from ambition to requirement

Although over half (51%) of organisations are already live with AI, a near equal half (47%), are still in the process of implementing AI capabilities in fraud and financial crime prevention, with go-live capabilities planned within the next 24 months.

02 Trust and oversight remain barriers

Despite fraud accelerating at unprecedented levels, the majority of organisations rely on human oversight for AI-powered decision making. While effective in the short term, human-in-the-loop models impact operational costs and limit the ability to achieve full operational resilience.

03 98% are pursuing advanced AI projects

Nearly a quarter (24%) are at an intermediate stage of current AI use in fraud and financial crime prevention. However, nearly all organisations are pursuing at least one advanced AI project, including Generative AI (76%), real-time anomaly detection (57%), and Agentic AI (51%).

04 Talent gaps expose limits

Just one in five firms report sufficient in-house data science expertise. Heavy reliance on outsourcing and cloud platforms underlines the need for AI tools that reduce dependency on scarce skillsets.

05 Regulatory hurdles loom, yet organisations feel prepared

As institutions upscale their AI capabilities for fraud and financial crime prevention, compliance with AI regulations remains the top internal challenge. Despite this, or perhaps because of it, 90% of organisations are confident in their abilities to comply with emerging AI legislation.

06 Data emerges as a critical priority

Data privacy risks in AI training emerges as the top global AI-driven threat, overtaking fraud itself. At the same time, 85% of organisations view data or intelligence exchange as extremely or quite valuable, reinforcing its central role in modern fraud prevention strategies.

07 Tactical wins outweigh strategic growth

Securing payment environments is the top priority in fraud and risk management for the next 12 months (42%), while customer experience objectives score far lower. Organisations must balance long-term growth objectives with short-term operational resilience.

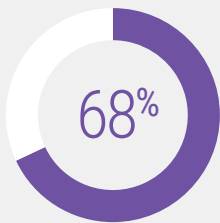
Trust, talent, and transition

The current AI landscape in fraud and financial crime prevention

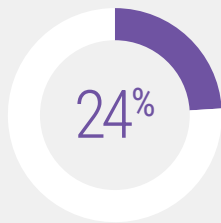
Our survey data reveals a clear shift toward advanced use of AI in fraud and financial crime prevention, with 68% of respondents reporting their current capabilities as ‘advanced real-time, adaptive AI integrated across channels’. This reflects the growing pressure on institutions to proactively address increasingly complex and sophisticated threats.

TOTAL RESPONSE

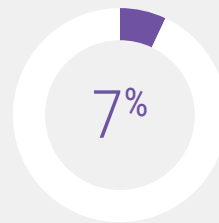
How would you describe your organisation's current use of AI in fraud and financial crime prevention?



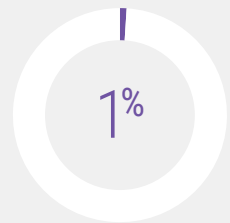
Advanced – real-time, adaptive AI integrated across channels



Intermediate – ML models for specific fraud use cases



Basic – limited automation and rules-based detection



Not using AI at all

Europe leads globally in adoption, with 74% of firms using advanced AI, closely followed by MEASA at 72%. Advanced uptake is slightly lower in NA (64%) and APAC (61%), indicating scope for deeper integration in these regions.

Nearly a quarter (24%) remain at an intermediate stage, using machine learning models for specific fraud use cases rather than deploying AI enterprise wide. Only 8% report using basic or no AI at all, evidence of a decisive move away from legacy, rules-based approaches toward more sophisticated solutions.

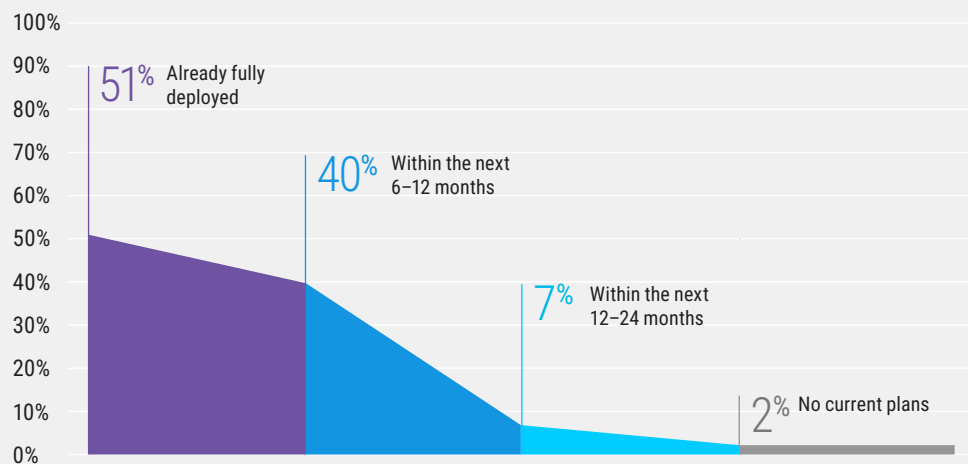
This divergence further underscores how organisation type influences AI maturity, with asset-based firms (over \$250 billion) reaching almost universal advanced AI adoption (97%). By contrast, revenue-based firms (\$500 million-\$1 billion) are advancing more gradually: 57% report advanced use, 29% remain at an intermediate stage, and 14% rely on basic use.

AI adoption is on the horizon for nearly half of organisations

Adoption is accelerating at pace, with half (51%) reporting already full deployment of AI capabilities in fraud and financial crime prevention, underscoring the urgency to harness AI to generate new revenue streams, fight fraud, and minimise disruption to protect legitimate customer transactions.

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is your organisation's current timeline for go-live AI capabilities in fraud and financial crime prevention?



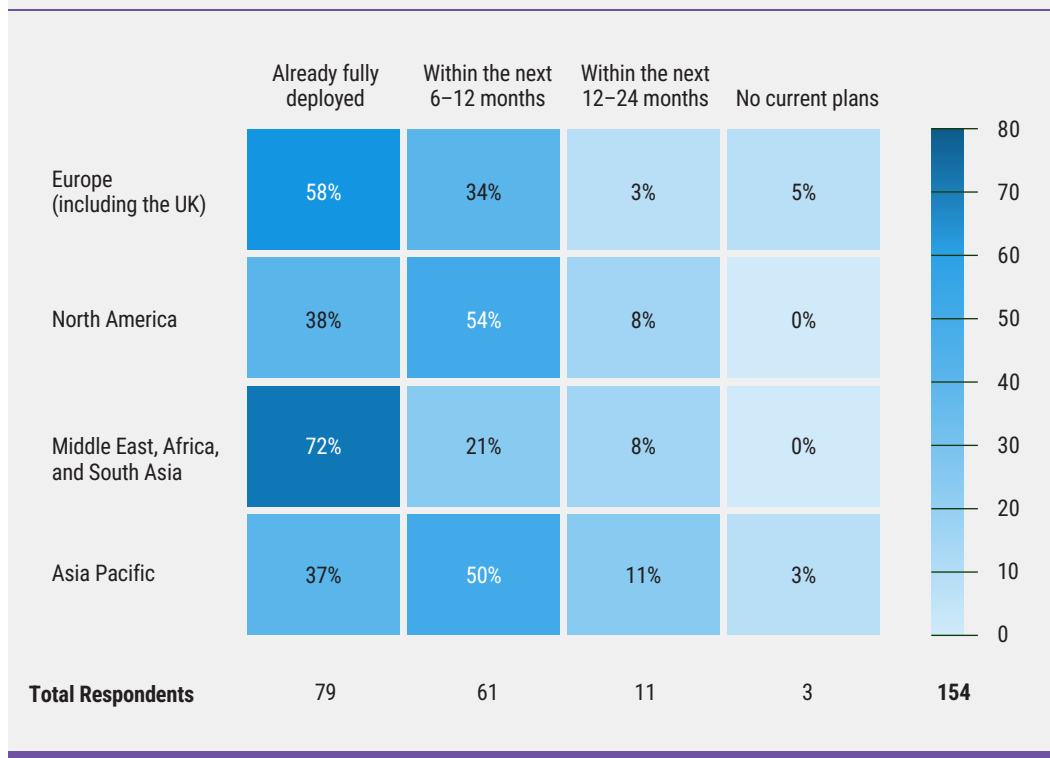
Nearly half of organisations are **in transition**, with **AI go-live** set within the next **24 months**.

The most telling story, however, lies in the middle of the market: a near equal half (47%), are still in the process of implementing AI, with go-live capabilities planned within the next 24 months. This segment represents a prime opportunity for partners to step in with proven, scalable solutions, and hands-on guidance to accelerate adoption.

Regional patterns reveal different drivers and challenges. MEASA leads with 72% already fully deployed, reflecting the region's soft law regulatory approach compared to Europe's stricter, risk-based regulation. NA and APAC are on the cusp of a wave of deployment, with strong momentum to go-live within the next 6-12 months.

REGIONAL LEVEL

What is your organisation's current timeline for go-live AI capabilities in fraud and financial crime prevention?



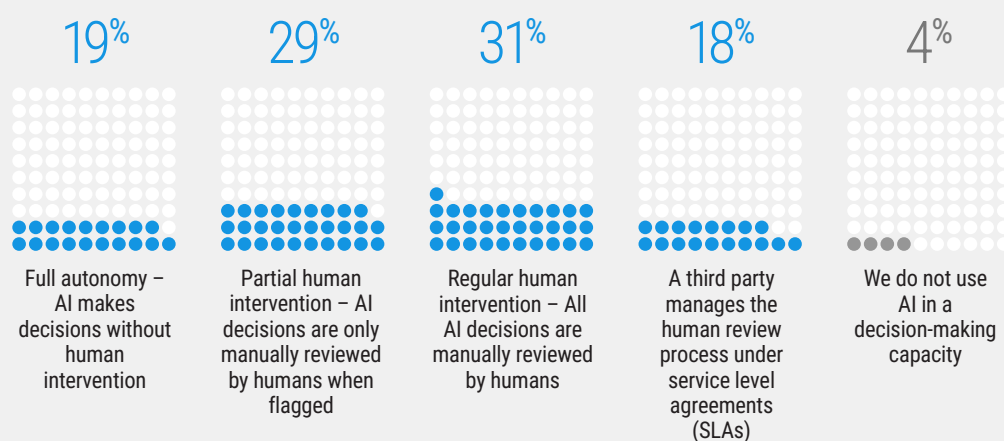
Only 2% of organisations have no current deployment plans, a clear signal that AI has moved from a future ambition to a core requirement in fraud and financial crime prevention.

Trust and human oversight shape the path to full AI autonomy

19% of organisations currently operate with full AI autonomy, led by Europe (32%), where stricter AI regulations are likely driving higher confidence and trust in automated decision-making.

TOTAL RESPONSE

How much manual control or human intervention is currently required for AI-powered decision making in your organisation's fraud and risk management operations?



However, the largest segment of organisations still rely on human oversight. 29% operate a partial human intervention model, reviewing AI decisions only when flagged, while 31% conduct a human review of all AI decisions — with this approach being most common in NA (46%) and MEASA (33%), reflecting a more cautious adoption strategy and stronger emphasis on a human-in-the-loop approach. Outsourcing also remains a key strategy, with 18% relying on third party review under service-level agreements, particularly in MEASA (23%) and APAC (21%). While effective in the short term, it is key to take into account how human-in-the-loop models increase operational costs and limit the ability to achieve full operational resilience.

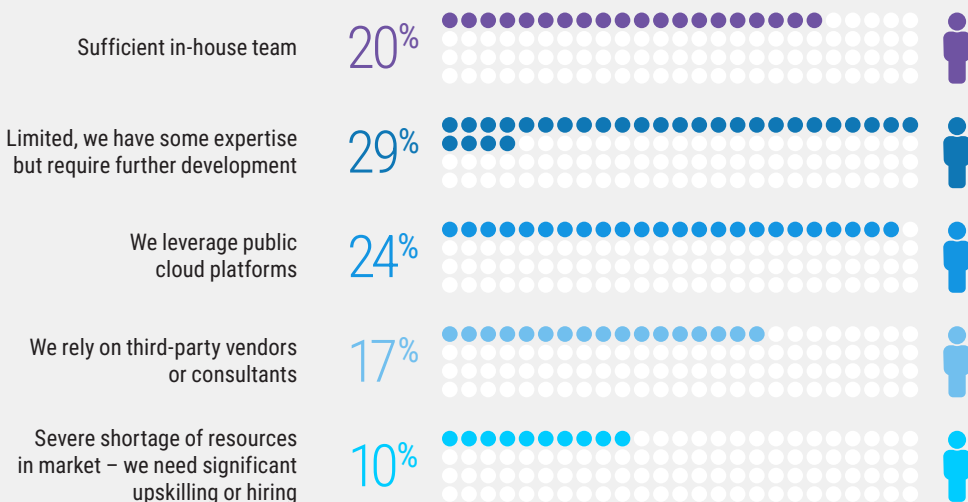
Across the board, institutions lack full trust in the AI technology stacks they have implemented. With fraud accelerating at unprecedented levels, accelerating automation powered by qualified data that only flags truly relevant transactions is critical. Without this, operations will continue to be hampered by unnecessary manual intervention, and the benefits of AI will remain constrained to short-term gains rather than delivering truly resilient, scalable fraud prevention.

Only one in five organisations report having a sufficient in-house data science team

Our survey data reveals a global challenge in accessing skilled data science talent for fraud and risk management, currently being addressed through a blend of upskilling, outsourcing, and cloud platforms. This underscores the need for AI driven tools that enable firms to better create and deploy new models, whilst minimising the dependency on specialised and costly skillsets, or on external vendors.

TOTAL RESPONSE

Describe your organisation's current access to data science talent for fraud and risk management functions



29% of respondents cite limited expertise but require further development, with this figure rising to 49% in MEASA, where regions such as the Middle East are [proactively future-proofing their AI talent pools](#).

Severe talent shortages affect 10% of firms.

The impact is most pronounced in NA (18%) and APAC (11%), where there is a more severe shortage of resources in the market. To bridge these gaps, 17% of organisations rely on third-party vendors or consultants, with outsourcing being a more common solution in Europe (24%) and MEASA (18%). Despite this as a solution to providing short-term support, it only maintains reliance on external expertise. Nearly one in four leverage public cloud platforms, led by Europe and APAC (both 32%), to supplement internal resource constraints.

With the rise of accelerated attacks and emerging fraud vectors, organisations require tools that allow them to rapidly build, test, and deploy new models without being constrained by lengthy and costly review cycles that can negatively affect financial performance, increase false declines and alerts, and heighten customer friction.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

GLOBAL RESPONSE



68% use advanced adaptive AI, yet only 19% operate full autonomy – showing room to unlock efficiency at scale.



AI has moved from ambition to necessity, with 51% live, 47% in transition (go-live within 24 months) – a prime opportunity for partners to help accelerate adoption.



Institutions lack full trust in their AI technology stacks with human-in-the-loop approaches dominating, increasing costs and slowing response times.



Talent shortages drive reliance on outsourcing and cloud platforms, highlighting the need for AI tools that reduce dependency on specialised and costly skillsets, or on external vendors.

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Europe

- Leads with 74% advanced AI adoption and 32% operating with full AI autonomy, driven by regulatory trust and stricter oversight.
- Outsourcing to combat talent access issues remains high (24%), creating long-term dependency risks.

NA

- Advanced AI adoption is lower (64%), with strong go-live momentum within 6-12 months.
- 46% manually review all AI decisions, making this the most cautious region – raising costs and slowing fraud response times.
- Severe talent shortages threaten the ability to scale advanced AI.

MEASA

- 72% have advanced AI, but 23% rely on third-party reviews, revealing structural fragility.
- Nearly half of firms (49%) cite limited data science expertise, using outsourcing (18%) to help mitigate talent gaps.

APAC

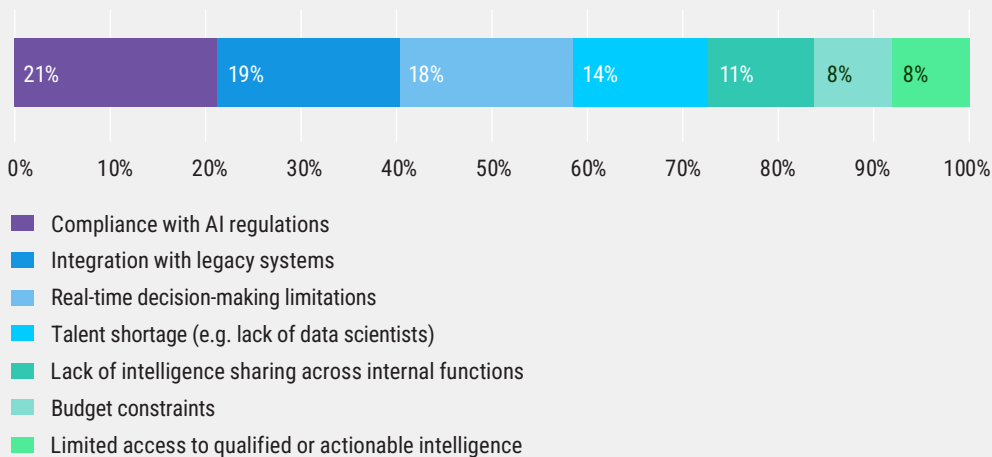
- Lowest advanced AI adoption (61%), but strong go-live momentum within 6-12 months.
- Cautious adoption: 33% manually review all AI decisions.
- Outsourcing dependence poses long-term resilience risks, with 32% leveraging public cloud platforms to mitigate talent gaps.

Navigating data and compliance challenges

As financial institutions continue to upscale their AI capabilities within their fraud and financial crime prevention, our survey data finds that the greatest internal challenge they face is compliance with AI regulations.

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is the greatest internal challenge faced when adopting AI for fraud and financial crime prevention?



This challenge is particularly pronounced throughout APAC (32%) and Europe (26%), who are polling above the global average of 21%. Today, AI regulation is [developing rapidly](#) throughout the world. Yet the risk for complexity grows as each jurisdiction approaches their frameworks through different lenses — from the US's drive towards deregulation, the EU's more stringent and centralised approach with the EU AI Act, or fragmented approaches in APAC.

Integration with legacy systems (19%) and real-time decision-making limitations (18%) closely follow as key challenges. This implies that financial organisations are increasingly shifting away from scaling and instead taking more tactical AI approaches to focus on integrating system decision-making capabilities. Unsurprisingly, as in many other modern banking contexts, legacy infrastructure is a key blocker growth.

05

Navigating data and compliance challenges in a fragmented industry

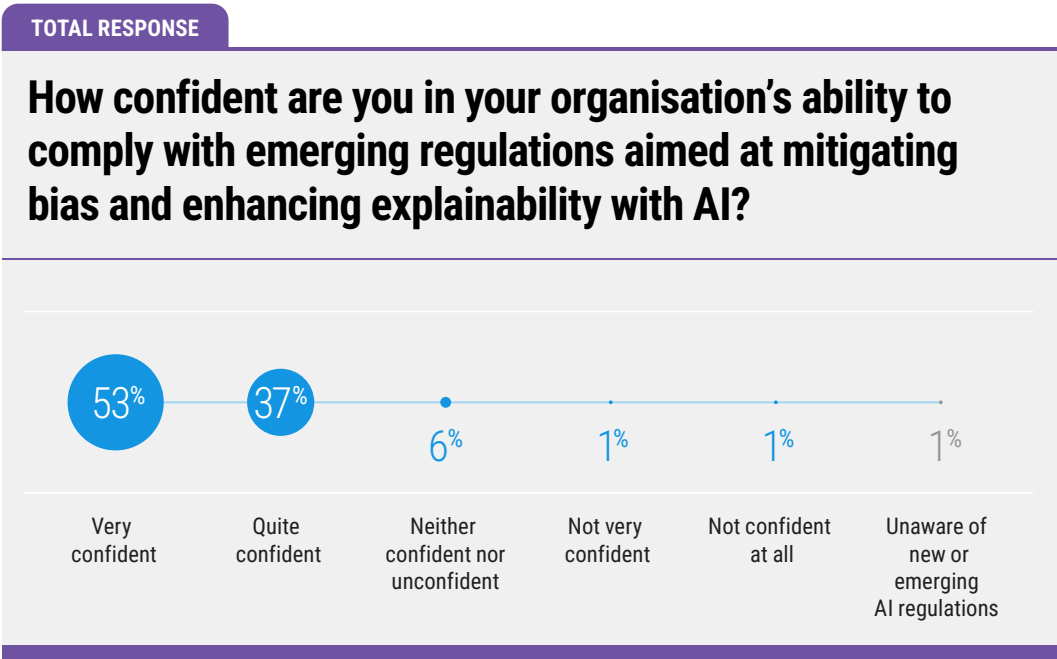
Talent shortages (14%) and lack of intelligence sharing across internal functions (11%) remain a consistent — though less pronounced — pain point globally, underscoring the high demand for skilled data scientists and AI specialists.

When looking at the organisational types, it stands out that the largest organisations identifying as asset-based (over \$250 billion) are struggling most with a lack of intelligence shared across internal functions (23%), shining a light on the challenges of internal fragmentation and siloes in organisations with this amount of operational complexity.

As AI continues to disrupt, complexities such as regulations, fraud, and customer preferences will only intensify. From AI agents handling payments completion to sophisticated, hard-to-detect fraud attempts, organisations must recognise that fraud and financial crime prevention is no longer a cost centre — it is a centre of excellence that drives revenue, retains margins, and strengthens customer relationships.

9 out of 10 are confident in compliance, despite regulation emerging as the key challenge.

However, even though regulation is seen as the key challenge — or maybe, because of it — over 90% of organisations are confident in their abilities to comply with emerging AI legislation.



Navigating data and compliance challenges in a fragmented industry

Looking at the regional data, the MEASA region shows the highest confidence level (62% ‘very confident’), which is in line with their flexible soft law approach.

Europe follows closely, with 55% of participants stating they are ‘very confident’ and nearly 32% ‘quite confident’. The European market is no stranger to comprehensive regulatory approaches (for example, the GDPR), so while regulatory compliance remains a challenge, the mandatory nature of these regulations in the region do not affect the confidence of the organisations’ ability to ultimately comply.

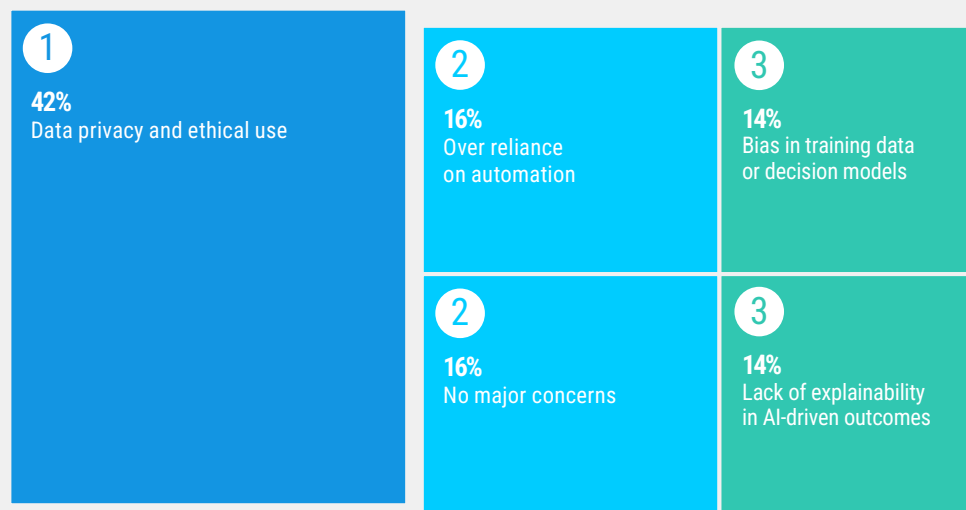
Notably, asset-based companies are more confident than organisations with a revenue-based business model. Data privacy and ethical use is the single greatest concern in AI decision-making.

When it comes to using AI in the fraud and risk decision-making, data privacy and ethical use emerge as the clear greatest concern for financial organisations and merchants.

Navigating data and compliance challenges in a fragmented industry

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is your organisation's greatest concern when using AI in fraud and risk decision making?



The over-reliance on automation, bias in training data and decision-making, and the lack of explainability are of significantly less concern (14-16%), highlighting the ever-prominent importance of data privacy as the key preoccupation in the sector. It is evident that it becomes increasingly crucial for organisations to take the Personally Identifiable Information (PII) out of their ecosystem while still being able to maintain a high level of precision in their processes and decision-making.

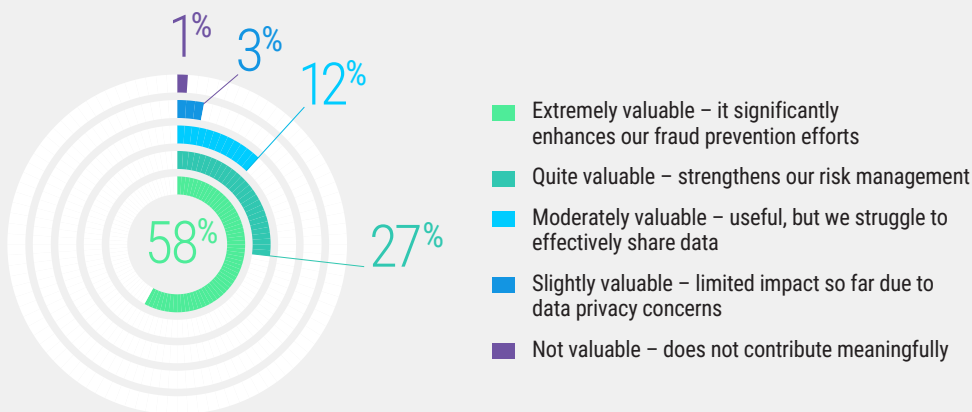
Notably, 16% of organisations report no major concerns, suggesting confidence in their existing AI governance frameworks. Yet the AI era is still in its infancy, with enormous potential yet to be realised. Many organisations are still exploring opportunities for AI to drive operational efficiency. To succeed, it's essential to keep reliance on automation within well-defined parameters, as self-learning is critical to reducing false positives and ensuring teams remain aligned with strategic initiatives.

Over half (58%) of organisations say **data exchange significantly enhances their fraud prevention efforts.**

To underscore the importance of data, nearly 85% of organisations view data or intelligence exchange as extremely or quite valuable, reinforcing its central role in modern fraud prevention strategies.

TOTAL RESPONSE

How valuable is data or intelligence exchange to your organisation in preventing fraud and financial crime?



Breaking down these results by organisational type, it's the technology and infrastructure providers, along with payment processors, that see the most value in data exchange, highlighting the ongoing battle between financial services incumbents and fintechs over data access. While this survey was conducted, [JP Morgan announced](#) startling new fees for fintechs, underscoring the emphasis financial organisations are placing on data in their risk management strategies.

Regionally, MEASA (67%) and Europe (63%) see the highest value for data exchange, whilst NA shows a higher proportion for 'quite valuable' (36%). This varied maturity in data or intelligence sharing practices comes as no surprise considering Europe's historically more advanced approach for data and intelligence exchange compared to NA.

Notably, 15% of organisations state they are struggling to effectively share data or have data privacy concerns, further stressing the need for effective intelligence sharing in anonymised form, which can reduce compliance risks as well as the dependency to share PII.

Navigating data and compliance challenges in a fragmented industry

Looking at these results holistically, it emerges that data in all its forms is absolutely crucial to the fraud and risk management strategies of financial organisations. As AI adoption accelerates, finding effective ways to securely manage, leverage, and exchange data will become even more critical. This is where collaboration comes into power. Sharing anonymised signals from telecommunications providers, social media platforms, and central infrastructures in a secure, encrypted format will help assess the legitimacy of accounts and transactions, strengthening safety across the payments ecosystem.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

GLOBAL RESPONSE



Compliance with AI regulations is the top internal challenge (21%), complicating scaling across jurisdictions. As AI continues to disrupt, so will regulation, fraud, and customer preference complexities. Firms must see fraud prevention as a centre of excellence driving revenue and customer loyalty, not just as a cost.



Data privacy and ethical use surpasses fraud itself as the leading concern, with 85% viewing data exchange as 'extremely/quite valuable' — strong governance and secure data exchange is critical for effective fraud prevention.

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Europe

- 26% cite AI compliance as a top challenge, yet compliance confidence is strong (55% 'very confident'), reflecting familiarity with structured compliance frameworks like GDPR.
- Strong emphasis on data exchange (63% high value), reflected by Europe's historically more advanced data exchange approach.

NA

- The risk for compliance complexity grows as each jurisdiction approaches their frameworks through different lenses — including the US's drive towards deregulation.
- Data or intelligence exchange is valued (36% 'quite valuable') but practises are less mature compared to Europe.

MEASA

- Highest regulatory confidence (62% 'very confident') due to flexible, soft-law approaches, enabling rapid AI deployment.
- Strong appreciation of data exchange (67% high value) presents opportunity.

APAC

- Challenges around compliance with AI regulations peak here (32%), reflecting fragmented and evolving regulatory frameworks, and increasing the complexity for multinational firms.

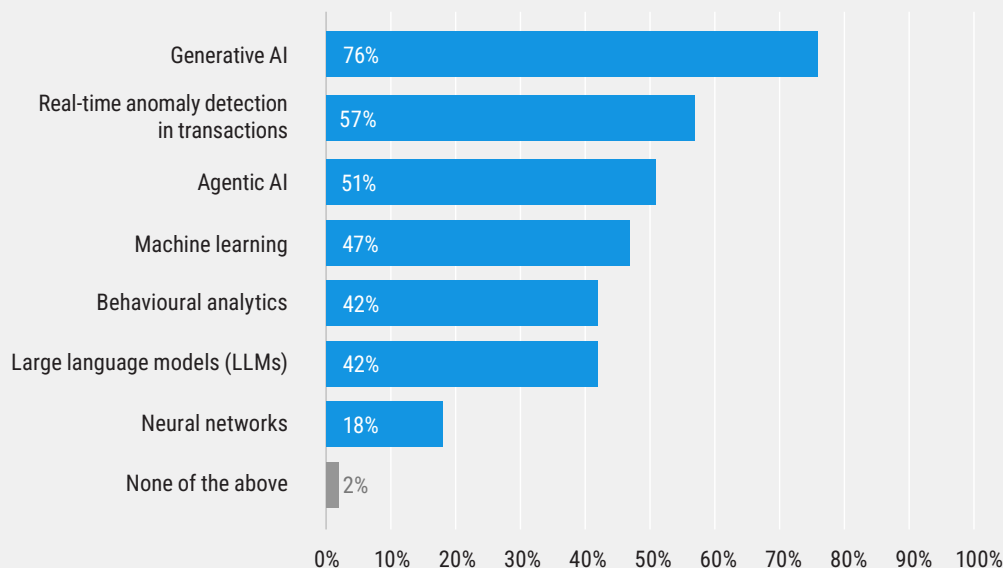
Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

Overall, nearly all organisations (98%) are pursuing at least one advanced AI project/initiative, underscoring a global consensus on the critical role of AI in fraud and financial crime prevention.

TOTAL RESPONSE

Which advanced AI projects/initiatives are your organisation prioritising to enhance fraud and financial crime detection?

Please select all that apply



Three-quarters (76%) of firms are prioritising Generative AI for fraud and financial crime detection. More than half of organisations are also focusing on real-time anomaly detection (57%) and Agentic AI (51%), reflecting broader industry trends toward greater adoption of Agentic AI technologies.

Generative AI overtakes other initiatives by **19** percentage points.

While still considered priorities, established technologies such as machine learning (47%), behavioural analytics (42%), and large language models (42%) are not currently at the forefront of AI investment. Revenue based organisations lead in adoption of these approaches, signalling a shift from post-authorisation risk checks to pre-authorisation fraud management in a real-time world, helping to predict and prevent scams, account takeovers, and other anomalies.

Regional trends reveal notable differences. APAC leads in machine learning adoption (55%), while NA, despite reporting slightly lower overall advanced AI adoption, shows a strong focus on Agentic AI (62%). In contrast, MEASA places lower priority on neural networks (13%) and Agentic AI (33%).

AI's disruptive nature extends beyond rising fraud vectors and evolving regulations — it plays an equally critical role in streamlining operations and upholding the integrity of payments. While our survey data signals varying strategic priorities for organisations across the globe, specific constants remain: AI is essential for customer satisfaction, minimising fraud, and optimising strategies.

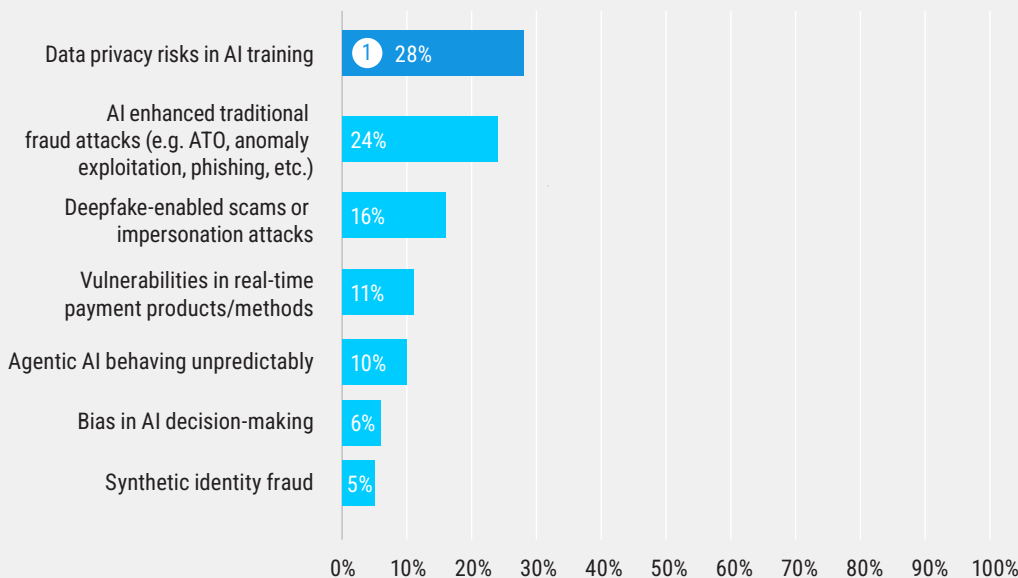
Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

Data privacy risks in AI rank above fraud as the top global threat

While fraud is often perceived as the top threat, our survey data shows that data privacy risks from AI training actually rank highest, followed by AI enhanced traditional fraud attacks.

TOTAL RESPONSE

What do you see as the greatest emerging AI-driven threat to fraud and financial crime over the next 12 months?



Cited by 28% of organisations, data privacy risks in AI training are seen as the greatest emerging AI-driven threat to fraud and financial crime over the next 12 months. This is led by MEASA (46%), reflecting heightened regional concern over how sensitive data is handled in increasingly AI-driven environments. While encouragingly, more organisations are beginning to address this challenge, many markets still overlook it.

AI enhanced traditional fraud attacks closely follows (24%), led by NA (28%) and Europe (26%). Concern for deepfake-enabled scams (16% globally), peaks in Europe (24%) and NA (18%).

Synthetic ID fraud appears low on the global radar (5%), likely due to how detecting it requires a sophisticated platform and high-quality, extensive dataset. Recent incidents such as [Monzo accepting customers claiming to live at 10 Downing Street and Buckingham Palace](#) illustrate the potential severity of such fraud, and the critical need to improve verification processes.

Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

APAC identifies vulnerabilities in real-time payments as the leading AI-driven threat (24%), more than double the global average (11%).

Regional differences in emerging AI-driven threats are also notable. With APAC leading in real-time payment adoption, these institutions are more aware of the risks associated with rapid payment innovation. This regional maturity underscores the importance of addressing vulnerabilities in real-time systems as global markets adopt similar capabilities.

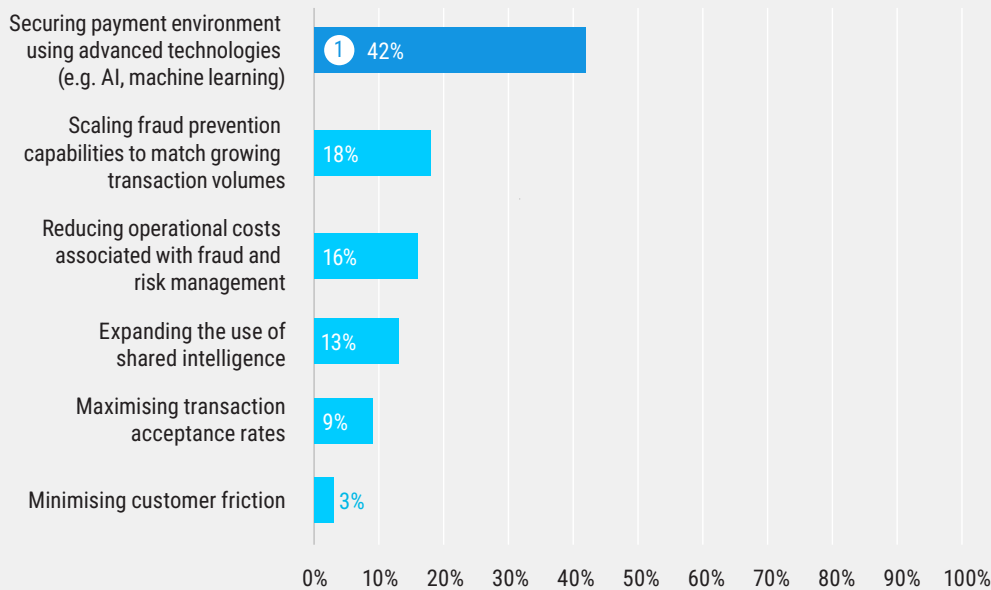
Concerns over other emerging AI-driven threats range between 5-10% globally, rounding out a diverse and evolving threat landscape where AI introduces both opportunities and new risks.

Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

Tactical priorities outweigh strategic objectives in fraud and risk management

TOTAL RESPONSE

What is your organisation's top strategic priority in fraud and risk management for the next 12 months?



Securing payment environments using advanced technologies is the leading priority for 42% of organisations globally, with APAC (50%) and NA (46%) showing the strongest focus. This priority is consistent across both asset and revenue-based organisations.

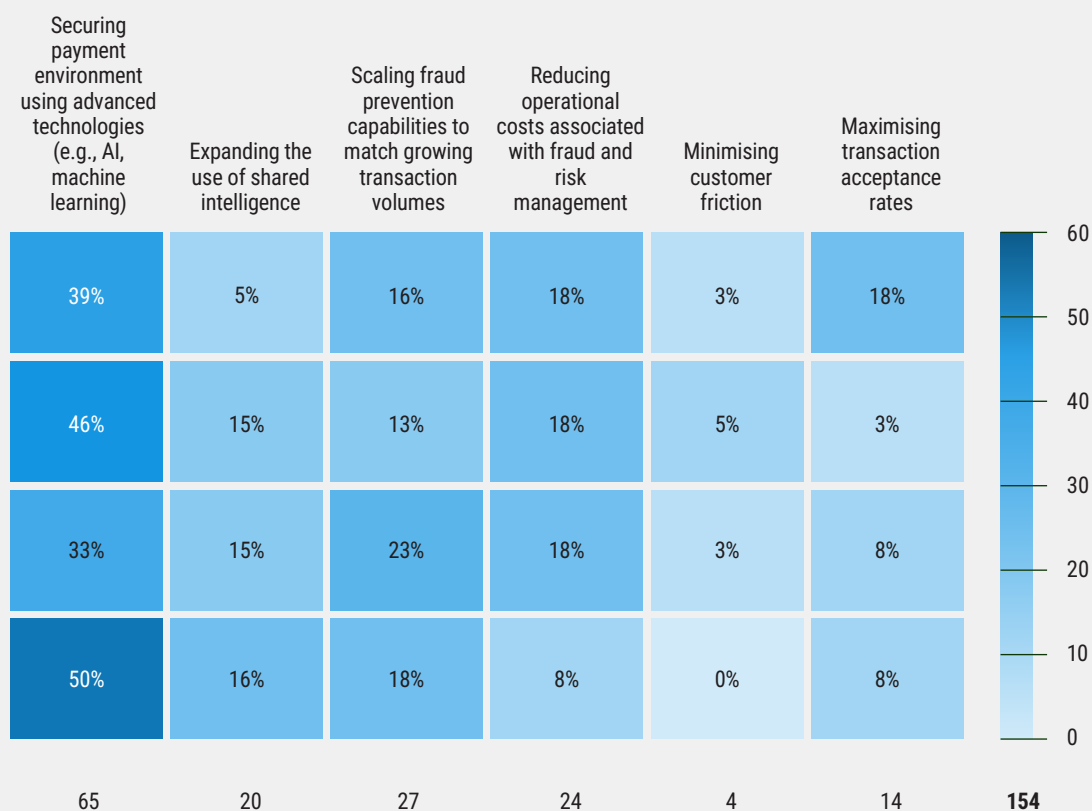
Scaling fraud prevention capabilities to match growing transaction volumes ranks second (18%), particularly emphasised in MEASA (23%) and APAC (18%). As firms secure their payment environments, scaling fraud prevention naturally becomes an operational necessity — a functional response to managing core risks and increasing transaction volumes effectively.

Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

Reducing fraud-related operational costs cited by 16% of respondents, is a notably low priority in APAC (8%), approximately 10 percentage points below other regions. Similarly, expanding the use of shared intelligence scores 15% for all other regions, with Europe standing out as an outlier at 5%. Meanwhile, maximising transaction acceptance rates and minimising customer friction are lower priorities, reflecting a shift from strategic objectives toward more tactical operational priorities.

REGIONAL LEVEL

What is your organisation's top strategic priority in fraud and risk management for the next 12 months?



Overall, the findings validate a broader trend: rather than focusing on scaling or growing their institution, organisations are concentrating on securing their existing technology and implementing tactical measures. It is key for organisations to note that this tactical focus, while essential for operational resilience, may come at the expense of more strategic objectives such as optimising transaction flows and enhancing customer experience.

Will securing today's systems come at the cost of tomorrow's growth?

Rather than pushing for growth or scaling, many institutions are turning inward, prioritising the security of existing technology and implementing tactical measures. While these steps are vital for operational resilience, they also expose a trade-off: the intense focus on short-term stability can sideline longer-term strategic goals, such as optimising transaction flows or enhancing customer experience. In essence, organisations are navigating a delicate balance between balancing immediate operational demands and building the foundation for tomorrow.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

GLOBAL RESPONSE



Nearly all organisations (98%) leverage at least one advanced AI project, with Generative AI (76%) most widely used, signalling a strategic shift from reactive to proactive fraud management.



While fraud is a concern, the top emerging threat is data privacy risks from AI training (28%). Highlighting a critical need to prioritise robust data governance and ethical AI practices to build trust and mitigate long-term risks.



Organisations are primarily focused on tactical, short-term goals for operational resilience. However, this can sideline strategic goals like minimising transaction acceptance rates/customer friction, crucial for future growth.

REGIONAL RESPONSE

Europe

- High concern for AI-enhanced traditional fraud attacks and deepfake scams, highlighting awareness of sophisticated, malicious AI use.
- Notably low focus on expanding the use of shared intelligence (5%), suggesting missed opportunity for collaborative defences against increasingly complex fraud schemes.

NA

- Despite lower overall AI adoption, strong focus on Agentic AI (62%), reflects broader industry trends.
- Highly concerned with AI-enhanced traditional fraud attacks and deepfake scams —reflecting a focus on combating advanced, AI-powered threats.

MEASA

- Prioritising scaling fraud prevention capabilities to handle growing transaction volumes.
- Highest concern for data privacy risks in AI training (46%), reflects heightened awareness of how sensitive data is handled, and a clear need for robust governance frameworks.

APAC

- Highest ML adoption (55%), and a real-time payments leader. Firms are hyper-aware of vulnerabilities in these rapid payment systems, identified as the leading AI-driven threat (24%).
- Securing payment environments and scaling fraud prevention to match transaction volumes are priorities and operational necessities.

Conclusion

As organisations worldwide navigate a growingly complex fraud and financial crime environment, the role of AI, qualified intelligence, and specialised expertise are becoming essential tools for intelligent orchestration.

It is evident that AI capabilities are being rapidly advanced to combat unprecedented levels of fraud and financial crime, with 98% predicted to have these capabilities live within the next 24 months. This urgency drives the need for AI tools that reduce dependency on specialised and costly skillsets, enabling banks and merchants to create and deploy new models efficiently.

Revenue based organisations are leading the adoption of established technologies such as machine learning, behavioural analytics, and large language models, reflecting a shift from post-authorisation risk checks to pre-authorisation fraud management in a real-time world. Self-learning AI within defined parameters is key, but institutions still struggle to fully trust their technology. As fraud accelerates, banks and merchants must increase automation to ensure only genuine threats are reviewed, while legitimate customers remain unaffected. True automation, however, relies on extensive, high-quality payments data. Therefore, effective data exchange and strong data privacy remain critical in modern fraud prevention strategies.

Securing payment environments and scaling fraud prevention are the immediate tactical priorities. However, objectives such as minimising customer friction and maximising transaction acceptance rates remain secondary. The challenge now is for organisations to evolve from pure tactical measures towards strategic innovation, ensuring they can keep pace with the fast-changing fraud landscape, transaction growth, increasingly sophisticated customers, and the wider regulatory environment.

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Finextra Research Ltd

77 Shaftesbury Avenue
London,
W1D 5DU
United Kingdom

team@finextra.com
www.finextra.com

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